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Quaestiones Morales et Legales — Tractatus VIII (Miscellaneous), Quaestiones XXIV–XXV (*Moral and Legal Questions*)

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QUESTION XXIV.

Whether it is *de fide* that the Pope cannot err in the Canonization of Saints?

SUMMARY.

When the Pope defines something de fide, he does not then receive from God a new revelation of the article defined. num. 1. Human actions are done prudently with only moral certitude. num. 2. It is heretical to deny the glory of a canonized Saint. num. 3. When a universal proposition which is believed de fide has been revealed, all the singulars evidently contained under that universal are also to be believed de fide. num. 4. Whether I ought de fide to believe that this infant baptized by me is in grace? num. 5. Whether this Host contains the body of Christ? num. 6. It is de fide that this man, e.g., Innocent the Tenth, is the legitimate Vicar of Christ. num. 7. It is de fide that the Pontiff, proposing laws to the whole Church, as regards morals, cannot err. num. 8. It is de fide that the contract of the Mons Pietatis is just. numer. 9. It is de fide that the Pontiff cannot err in the approbation of Religious orders. num. 10. In what way the whole Church cannot err? num. 11. & 13. The Pontiff's definition in matters of faith presupposes human diligence, yet does not rest upon this, but upon the assistance of the Holy Spirit. num. 12.

They commonly deny it, in such wise that they say that to deny the glory of a canonized Saint is temerarious, scandalous, and impious, but not heretical. Thus St. Thomas *quolib.* 9. *art.* vlt. St. Antoninus 3. *p.* *artic.* 12. *c.* 8. Cajetan *opusc. de Indulg. cap.* vlt. Cano *de locis Theolog. lib.* 5. *cap.* 5. Bañez 2.2. *quæst.* 1 *art.* 10. *dub.* 7. *concl.* 2. Suárez *de fide, disp.* 5. *sect.* 8. *num.* 8. Turrianus 2.2. *disp.* 17. *dub.* 6. *in fine.* Bellarmine *lib.* 1. *de Sanct. cap.* 9.

It is proved first, because canonization rests upon human testimonies, which are fallible.

1. Secondly, because when the Pontiff defines something *de fide*, he does not then receive from God a new revelation of the article defined: but from the infallible assistance of the Holy Spirit, after due and moral consultation, he declares and infallibly discloses the revealed truth pre-existing in the Scriptures: but in the Scriptures nothing is contained concerning the sanctity of this canonized one: therefore the Pontiff cannot define, as certain *de fide*, that this man is a Saint.

Thirdly, with equal certitude of faith is believed the presence of the Body of Christ in a duly consecrated Host, and the glory of the Just who die in the Lord without any fault, or without any debt of punishment: but the presence of Christ in this Host is not to be believed *de fide*: therefore neither is the glory in this canonized one to be believed *de fide*; because just as it is not infallibly established that it was duly consecrated, so neither is it infallibly established that this man died in grace; for human testimonies are fallible, especially since the heart of man is inscrutable.

It is confirmed: the Pope could not define, as certain *de fide*, that this Host contains the Body of Christ: therefore neither can he define, as certain *de fide*, that this man is in glory.

Fourthly, in order that the Church not err, it suffices that the glory of the canonized be morally certain, although it be not infallible, nor *de fide*. 2. The reason is, because human actions are done prudently with only moral certitude, thus Lorca 2.2. *qu.* 1. *art.* 3. *disp.* 10. *num.* 17. Lugo *de Sacram. pœnit. disp.* 7. *sect.* 13. *num.* 269. But the cult and veneration of a Saint is a human action; therefore it is done without error, if he be venerated with moral certitude concerning the Saint's glory; although this glory be not *de fide*, nor infallible: therefore the Pope does not lead the Church into error, even if in truth that canonized one were not in glory; because moral certitude alone concerning his glory removes from the Church all danger of error.

Fifthly, because, as Cano says *lib. 5. cap. 5. q. 5. concl. 2.*, although the Pontiff, in defining those things which are of necessity for salvation, has the infallible assistance of the Holy Spirit — whence it is *de fide* that he cannot err by defining something to be honorable which is vicious — nevertheless it is not of necessity for salvation to honor and venerate this man as a Saint; therefore it is not *de fide*, nor heretical, although it be temerarious, to assert that the Pope can err in the canonization of Saints.

Sixthly, because the Pontiff in the canonization of St. Bonaventure said: *We decree that he be held a Saint*, and Sixtus V in the canonization of St. Didacus of Alcalá: *We command that he be venerated as a Saint*; therefore, since he did not say *we define*, the Pontiff defines nothing as certain *de fide*; but only declares that his glory is morally certain, and cannot be denied without temerity.

3. These things notwithstanding, however, the answer is in the affirmative, namely that the glory of a canonized Saint is to be believed *de fide*, thus Valencia 2. 2. *disp. 1. punc. 7. q. 6: §. 40. vers. itaque*, John of Naples *quodlib. 11.*, who teaches: *That it is heretical to deny it*, Castro Palao *tract. 4. disp. 1. punct. 5. §. 4.*, and that this opinion is probable teaches Turrianus 2.2. *disp. 16. dub. 3. vers. 3. & disp. 17. dub. 6. vers. 2. opinio*, Comitoli *respons. lib. 1. q. 99. num. 3.*

Hence many teach that the Pope cannot delegate canonization to another, nor to a General Council, because he alone can define matters of faith, thus Castellinus *de Canoniz. SS. qu. 3. art. 2.* Barbosa, who amasses many [authors], *in cap. 1. num. 6. 7. & 8. de venerat. Sanctor.* For to Peter alone was it said, *Confirm thy brethren*; wherefore the Decrees of a General Council, legitimately assembled, even with the Apostolic Legates assenting and subscribing, are not, before the Pope's approbation, certain *de fide*: Cajetan *tract. de author. Papæ, & Concil.* Torquemada *de Ecclesia, lib. 3. cap. 6. 8. & 38.* Cano *lib. 5. cap. 5.*

4. It must be noted, for the understanding of the following argument, that when a universal proposition which is believed *de fide* has been revealed, all the singulars contained under that universal evidently — that is, without prudent fear — are immediately revealed and are to be believed *de fide*; e.g., when this proposition has been revealed, every murderer is deprived of the grace of God, it is also immediately revealed that I, now committing homicide out of great deliberation, am deprived of the grace of God, and I am bound to believe *de fide* that I, now advertently killing a man, am deprived of the grace of God; because I evidently know that I kill deliberately, and thus I evidently know that this singular is

contained in the universal; thus commonly the Theologians, Cano, Vega, Valencia, and others, whom follow Suárez *de fide disp. 3. sect. 11. num. 2. & 5.* Hurtado, proving it at length, *de fide disp. 11.* the Most Eminent Lugo *de fide, disp 1. sect. 13. §. 3. & 4.*

The reason is, because God, revealing, sees most distinctly all the singulars comprehended in the universal: but the singulars are not distinguished from the universal, but constitute that collection; wherefore God, revealing the universal, immediately also reveals the singulars, which are as it were the parts composing the universal collection.

But it must be evidently established — that is (as Lugo well teaches §. 4. *num. 312.*), without prudent fear — that this singular is contained in the universal; for if this were not altogether evident, but it could prudently be feared whether it were contained, then the singular proposition would not be *de fide*, because the assent of faith bespeaks complete certitude, and excludes all fear.

That the singular is contained in the universal — this need not be revealed, but it suffices that it be altogether evident, so that it cannot prudently be feared [to be otherwise], as is clear in the example set forth: I ought to believe *de fide*: that I, now sinning deliberately, am deprived of the grace of God, although that I sin deliberately I know not from revelation, but evidently. It is proved from parity, because in order that a revealed proposition be *de fide*, nothing else is required except that we cannot prudently fear whether it is God who has revealed it; therefore in order that a singular object be *de fide*, nothing else is required except that we cannot prudently fear whether God has spoken of this object. For why is more required (says Lugo *num. 307.*) for believing that God speaks of something? than for believing that God speaks?

5. Hence it is that the same object is to be believed *de fide* by one, not by another; e.g., I, with due form, with water then taken from the sea, baptized an infant; I am bound to believe *de fide*: *That this infant is in grace*, because it is evident to me that he has been duly baptized, and thus that this singular is comprehended in the revealed universal proposition, *That all infants duly baptized are in grace*: but another is not bound to believe it *de fide*, because to him my right intention is not evident, and thus it is not evident to him that the singular is contained in the universal.

6. But by no one — not even by the consecrating Priest — is the presence of the Body of Christ in this Host to be believed *de fide*, because to no one can it be evident that it has been duly consecrated; for the consecrating Priest can doubt whether the host be of wheat, whether the flour was mixed with elemental water, whether he was duly ordained, whether the one ordaining was truly a Bishop, or the Bishop himself duly ordained.

7. So it is to be believed *de fide* that this man, Our Most Holy Lord Innocent the Tenth, is the legitimate Pontiff, and the Vicar of Christ in the whole Church; thus Salmeron, Valencia, and Albertini, whom follow Suárez *de fide disp.* 5. *sect.* 8. *num.* 12. & *disp.* 10. *sect.* 5. Hurtado *de fide disp.* 37. Lugo *de fide disp.* 1. *sect.* 13. §. 5. Comitoli *responsorum lib.* 1. *qu.* 99. The reason is, because by this very fact, that the whole Church and all acknowledge him as legitimately elected, his legitimate election is evidently established, so that it cannot prudently be feared [to be otherwise]: therefore it is evident that this singular is contained in the universal revealed proposition, that the legitimate successor of Peter is the Vicar of Christ. These things being laid down,

Our conclusion is proved first. This universal proposition is *de fide* and immediately revealed: *Blessed are the clean of heart, for they shall see God*; therefore all the singulars which evidently — that is, without prudent fear — are contained in that universal are immediately revealed: but the canonized Saint is a singular which evidently, and without prudent fear, is contained in the universal, because canonization, on account of the extraordinary diligence employed, makes it evident, and without prudent fear, that he departed with a clean heart: therefore it is *de fide* to believe, and it is immediately revealed by God, that St. Francis, e.g., canonized, sees God.

8. It is proved secondly: it is *de fide* that the Pope, proposing laws to the whole Church as regards morals, cannot err: but the Pope, canonizing, proposes laws to the whole Church as regards morals; therefore it is *de fide* that the Pope, canonizing, cannot err.

That the Pope, proposing laws to the whole Church as regards morals, cannot err — declaring to be good what is evil, and contrariwise — and that this is *de fide*, is taught by St. Antoninus 3. *par. tit.* 12. *c.* 8. §. 2. John of Naples *quodlib.* 11. Cano

de locis Theol. lib. 5. cap. 5. Molina de Iust. tom. 2. disp. 325. Suárez de fide disp. 5. sect. 8. num. 7. Turrianus 2.2. disp. 16. dub. 2. Castro Palao tom. 1. tract. 4. disp. 1. pun. 5. §. 3. Comitoli lib. 1. responsorum qu. 113. num. 4.

This is clear, because otherwise the whole Church would be led into error; but the Church cannot err, because she is *the Pillar and ground of the truth*, 1. Tim. 2. & Ioan. 14., she has the promised infallible assistance of the Holy Spirit, who *will teach her all truth*: then, because otherwise the Church would not have a certain rule of her faith, which is her visible head, the Roman Pontiff.

9. Hence, of the contract, e.g., of the Mons pietatis, declared licit by Leo X, it is *de fide* that it is just: Molina *disp. 325. Turrianus disp. 16. dub. 2. Bellarmine de Rom. Pontif. lib. 4. cap. 10.*

10. So too it is *de fide* that the Pontiff cannot err in the approbation of religious orders: Turrianus *disput. 16. dub. 4. vers. 4. Castro Palao tom. 1. tr. 4. disp. 1. punc. 5. §. 6.*

That the Pontiff, canonizing, proposes to the whole Church laws as regards morals, obliging her, in such wise that if he erred he would lead the whole Church into error, is clear; for to venerate a damned man, and to take him as intercessor before God, is evil in itself, and if it be done culpably, it will be a mortal sin: **11.** But when it is said that the Church cannot err, this is not taken only of culpable error, such that she should err culpably, but of any error whatsoever, even material and inculpable; otherwise in no article would it be certain that the Church does not err: then, because otherwise the Holy Spirit would not infallibly assist the Church, nor would he teach her *all truth*; nor would the Church be *the Pillar and ground of the truth*; nor would the Church be Christ's *immaculate Spouse, without spot and without wrinkle*; because any error whatsoever in the whole Church, although inculpable, is against her sanctity and purity and the infallible truth of the articles which she believes.

From what has been said, the response to the contrary arguments is clear.

12. To the first it is answered, that in the definition of any article whatsoever the Pontiff is bound beforehand to employ moral diligence, by searching the Scriptures, by consulting learned men, because he has the assistance of the Holy Spirit promised in such wise that he should proceed in defining in a human manner, and it evidently pertains to the providence of the Holy Spirit that the diligence necessary be not passed over: but when he thereafter defines, then that

definition, and the certitude of faith, does not rest upon human diligence and previous counsel, but upon the divine promise of the assistance of the Holy Spirit: Suárez *de fide disp. 5. sect. 8. num. 11. Valencia 2. 2. disp. 1. punct. 7. qu. 6. §. huc accedit*, Castro Palao *tract. 4. disp. 1. pun. 5. §. 2. num. 12.*

To the second, the answer is clear from what was said in the first proof.

To the third, there is a disparity, because there can be no evidence that this host has been duly consecrated; but it can evidently, and without prudent fear, be established, from most worthy witnesses, concerning the virtues and miracles of the canonized, in life and after death; and when it is evidently, and without prudent fear, established that some singular proposition is contained in a revealed universal, then this suffices for that singular object to be believed with divine faith, as I have shown above.

Moreover, another disparity is brought forward, because if a host be not duly consecrated, not the whole Church, but a few men err; nor is that host proposed for adoration to the whole Church by the Pontiff defining laws from the chair: but if a damned man were venerated as a Saint, the whole Church would err — nay, would be led into error by her head, the Roman Pontiff, defining from the chair that he is a Saint.

13. To the fourth: that error would indeed be inculpable; but it is impious to assert that the whole Church, although inculpably, can err, because the same could be said of any article of faith whatsoever, and this would be against the promised assistance of the Holy Spirit, who teaches her all truth, nor would the Church be the pillar and ground of the truth.

To the fifth it is answered, that although it be not of necessity for salvation to venerate this man as a Saint, it is nevertheless of necessity for salvation not to venerate a damned man, nor to take him as intercessor before God, nor to offer sacrifices to God in his honor; for if a damned man were knowingly venerated, assuredly a most grievous sacrilege would be committed: therefore, just as in the other things which, if they were done knowingly, would be sacrileges, it is *de fide* that the Pope cannot err in approving them as honorable — since knowledge of them is of necessity for salvation — so he cannot err in the cult of the Saints.

To the sixth it is answered, that those words of canonization, *We decree, we command, that he be held a Saint*, are equivalent to the word *we define*, according as it is contained in the Bull of canonization of St. Francis of Paola, which Surius reports *tom. 2. die 2. Aprilis*, there: *We define that he has already been received among the Choirs of the Blessed*.

QUESTION XXV.

Whether it is *de fide* that the Pope cannot err in Beatification, or whether the glory of the canonized and of the beatified is to be believed with equal certitude?

SUMMARY.

Some deny it. numer. 1. others more probably affirm it. numer. 2. The glory of the beatified is proposed to the whole Church to be believed. numer. 3. The whole Church, in honor of a Blessed, offers to God the sacrifice which is celebrated in a single place. num. 4. Whether after Beatification new diligences are made, and why? numer. 5.

1. Turrianus 2.2. *disp. 17. dub. 6.* and Castellinus *de certa gloria Sanctorum cap. 2. num. 11.* deny it.

First, because the canonized is proposed to the whole Church to be venerated: but the beatified to a certain Province: therefore the glory of the canonized is proposed as certain *de fide*; but that of a Blessed as morally certain.

Secondly, because after Beatification new inquiries are made, and an examination concerning the miracles and the sanctity of life of the one to be canonized, even if he has been beatified: therefore the glory of the beatified is not certain *de fide*.

Thirdly, because the Pontiff, canonizing, uses the word *we define*, saying, *we define that he is in glory*, as is clear from the Bull of Canonization of St. Francis of Paola, which Surius reports *tom. 2. die 2. April.*, which word he does not use in Beatification.

2. These things notwithstanding, however, the answer is in the affirmative, and thus that the glory of the canonized and of the beatified is to be believed *de fide* and with equal certitude. Thus Castro Palao *tom. 1. tract. 4. disp. 1. pun. 5. §. 5. num. 4.* Megalius *V. Canonizatio num. 1.*

3. It is proved first: the glory of the canonized is for this reason to be believed *de fide*, because his glory is proposed to the whole Church to be believed: but the glory of a Blessed is also proposed to the whole Church to be believed: therefore the glory of both is to be believed with equal certitude of faith. The minor is proved, because although the cult of the sacred Office and of the Mass is granted to a Blessed for a certain province only, nevertheless it is proposed not to one Province alone, but to the whole Church of God, that he be named Blessed, and worthy to be invoked by the faithful as intercessor before the Divine Majesty; and this is clear from the practice of the Church herself; for in any place whatsoever of the Christian world a Blessed can be invoked, and vows can be made to him, gifts offered, and he taken as intercessor before God, and all this is done by the authority of the head of the Church, the Roman Pontiff beatifying; nay indeed, Castro Palao *tom. 1. tract. 4. de fide disp. 1. pun. 5. §. 5. num. 7.* and Antonio Quintanadueñas *Singularium moralium tract. 1. singul. 5.* teach, not improbably, that a votive Mass in honor of a Blessed can be celebrated in the whole world, by any Priest whatsoever; because by this very fact, that the Pope approves it for one place, the impediment is removed, by Pontifical authority, for any place whatsoever.

It is proved secondly, for although in one place alone the sacrifice is offered to God in honor of a Blessed, nevertheless that sacrifice the whole Church offers, which through the Priest, as the public Legate of the whole Church, offers sacrifice to God: therefore the whole Church, in the person of the Priest, takes the Blessed as intercessor before God; therefore truly the whole Church errs by the authority of her head, if by the authority of the same the Priest alone should err. It is confirmed, because it is for this reason *de fide* that a legitimate universal Council, assembled and approved by the Pope, cannot err; because if the council erred, those, e.g., 300 Fathers of the Council would not err, but the whole Church would err; for the Fathers of a legitimate and universal Council represent the whole Church: therefore if the Priest alone, by Pontifical authority, should err, the whole Church would err, because the Priest represents the whole Church while, by the authority of the Church's head, he takes the Blessed as intercessor before God. So too the whole Kingdom renders obedience to the Supreme Pontiff while the public legate of the Kingdom shows obedience to him. Hence, although it be lawful to venerate privately one not beatified, nevertheless it has never been lawful, even most

secretly, to recite the Office, or to celebrate Mass in his honor; because this cult is public, which is offered by a Priest or another Minister in the name of the whole Church.

It is proved thirdly, because the same Turrianus, *d. disp. 17. dub. 6. in fine*, teaches that it is temerarious, scandalous, and impious to deny the glory of the beatified: but it is temerarious for this reason, because it is evident, without any prudent fear, on account of the immense diligence in so great a business, that he died in the Lord, and is accepted by God, on account of the miracles in life and after death: therefore if it is evident that he died with a clean heart, it immediately follows that it is *de fide* that he sees God: for when this universal proposition has been revealed, *Blessed are the clean of heart, for they shall see God*, all the singulars which it is evidently established are contained in that universal are also immediately revealed, as I explained at length above in the preceding question, wherefore I dwell on it no further.

To the first argument, therefore, of the contrary opinion it is answered, that the beatified is proposed to one Province alone to be venerated with the honor of the sacred Office and of the Divine sacrifice: but to the whole Church he is proposed as worthy to be invoked as intercessor before God, as is clear from daily practice, for in every place of the Church he is invoked by the Faithful by Pontifical authority; therefore it is said gratuitously that the glory of a Blessed is not proposed as certain *de fide*, but morally.

To the second it is answered that I have received from a most pious man, and most expert in this matter, P. D. Giovanni Battista Castaldo — seeing that he was procurator in the cause of the beatification of Bl. Cajetan and of Bl. Andrew — that after Beatification no new diligences are made as regards the virtues, nor as regards the miracles in life, nor as regards the miracles wrought after death before beatification, but only witnesses are examined concerning the perseverance of the cult, that is, that the faithful after Beatification have persevered in the veneration and cult of the Blessed, and concerning the perseverance of miracles, that is, that after beatification, by the new intercession of the Blessed, miracles have been wrought by God. But such diligences concerning the perseverance of the cult and of the miracles are not made for this reason, as if there were doubt about the glory of the beatified, since no diligence is made concerning the virtues, which are truly the cause of glory; but they are made because, since the glory of the beatified is to be solemnly defined, and the honor of office and of sacrifice is to be decreed for him in the whole Church, therefore [they are made] for the greater solemnity of the

Canonization; and because, although it be certain *de fide*: that he is in glory; it is nevertheless not fitting that anyone whosoever existing in glory be decreed to be honored with the public cult of an office in the whole Church; but only he of whom it is most fully ascertained that, on account of heroic virtues, signified by a multitude of miracles, he is most accepted by God, and is held in an eminent degree of sanctity, and in great devotion among the faithful; therefore new diligences are made concerning the perseverance of the cult and of the miracles, that the eminent sanctity, and the extraordinary devotion among the Faithful, may be shown, whence he may fittingly be solemnly canonized, and the honor of an office be decreed for him in the whole Church.

To the third it is answered that it matters little what words the Pontiff uses, whether in Canonization or in Beatification; for it is enough that he declares his glory to the whole Church; for if he erred, the whole Church would be led into error by the Pontiff's authority.

You will object: the cult of a Blessed is proposed as certain; not with the certitude of faith, but with moral certitude.

I answer: it could similarly be said: that the cult of a canonized Saint is proposed as certain; not with the certitude of faith, but with moral certitude; which, however, the adversaries deny, asserting that the glory of a canonized Saint is certain *de fide*. Moreover, from this — because moral certitude does not lack some fear of erring, and because it is unfitting that the whole Church be led into error by the Pontiff — therefore, according to the more common opinion, the glory of a canonized Saint is proposed as certain with the certitude of faith, lest the whole Church be led into error: therefore by parity of reason, lest the whole Church be led into error in the cult of a Blessed, it is proposed as certain, with the certitude of faith.